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The Metaphysics of Indeterminacy: Postmodern Religious Theory and the Ruin of Referentiality

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The glory of Him who moveth all that is
 Pervades the universe, and glows more bright
 In the one region, and another less.

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-- Dante, *The Divine Comedy*

Shall some selected appearances rule the others? We shall have to verify this selection by another selection, the second by a third, and thus it will never be finished.

-- Michel de Montaigne, *Apology for Raymond Sebond*

And the last, throughout to make enumerations so complete, and reviews so comprehensive, that I could be sure of leaving nothing out.

-- René Descartes, *Discourse on Method*

Pyramids, arches, obelisks, were but the irregularities of vainglory, and wild enormities of ancient magnanimity. But the most magnanimous resolution rests in the Christian religion, which trampleth upon pride, and sits on the neck of ambition, humbly pursuing that infallible perpetuity unto which all others must diminish their diameters, and be poorly seen in angles of contingency.

Pious spirits who passed their days in raptures of futurity made little more of this world than the world that was before it, while they lay obscure in the chaos of pre-ordination, and night of their force-beings. And if any have been so happy as truly to understand Christian annihilation, ecstasies, exolution, liquefaction, transformation, the kiss of the spouse, gustation from God, and ingression into the divine shadow, they have already had an handsome anticipation of heaven; the glory of the world is surely over, and the earth in ashes unto them.

To subsist in lasting monuments, to live in their productions, to exist in their names and predicament of chimeras, was large satisfaction unto old expectations, and made one part of their Elysiums. But all this is nothing in the metaphysics of true belief. To live indeed is to be again ourselves, which being not only hope but an evidence in noble believers, 'tis all one to lie in St. Innocent's churchyard, as in the sands of Egypt: ready to be anything, in the ecstasy of being ever, and as content with six foot as the moles of Adrianus.

*Tabesne cadavera solvat,
 An rogos, hand refert.*

-- Lucan

--Sir Thomas Browne, *Hydriotaphia, Urn-Burial*

Pure Being without exteriority, without analogical reference, giving rise to a desire [¹] to find one's way from here to there'Dante, Montaigne, Descartes . . . The seventeenth century theological

vision of a bicameral reality guides Sir Thomas Browne's (1605-1682) [^2] poetic affirmation of faith to a distressed compromise between doubt and reason. This "fideism" or futility of a this-worldliness against the infinitude of God makes clear his belief in a life lived ingressing into the "divine shadow." Not Descartes and certainly not Montaigne, Browne advances a theory of religion as a resolvable disjunction between blind faith and rational and skeptical processes. The finality of his judgment comes only in a form of condemnation of the here and now, the finite. It is a necessary repudiation if one follows a deconstructive logic, insofar as the limitless derives its value from the limited, negatively. The materiality of this world gives way to the spirituality of the next, forming not a dialectical synthesis but an annihilation of the former. Monuments, pyramids and obelisks, for Browne, are further testament to the failure of the material-temporal to satisfactorily render the divine. And yet "noble" and common believers dedicate monuments in all forms to ephemeral lives, last signs of a continuity between an ever-expanding singularity and its deictic parameter, all last signs, "ready to be anything, in the ecstasy of being ever." From Browne's text, God becomes the *telos* and (necessarily) the process by which everything is annihilated and again restored. God is that which equates the solidity of marble and the fluidity of sand, form and dissemination, with finality a subdued readiness to become anything, all things without end. The invocation of an ecstatic God, not an "immortal diamond" as Gerard Manley Hopkins would later declare, a God in process representing an "infallible perpetuity" making time and space immeasurable by the fact that measure is impossible, creates a radical limitlessness in the center of theology, an epistemological infidelity by which the concept of God in Christianity, through the perpetuity of creation in the resurrection, exceeds its own ideational boundary.

> "To the limit," it will be argued, still presupposes a limit. Here, limit \[_peras_\] no longer

> In all ages men have spoken of an absolutely necessary being, and in so doing have endeavoured the existence of which is impossible. But this yields no insight into the conditions which make it the existence of a thing as absolutely unthinkable. It is precisely these conditions that we desire

1. _The Logic of Sense_

Philosophy merges with ontology, but ontology merges with the univocity of Being (analogy 1

2. _Difference and Repetition_

Representation essentially implies an analogy of being. However, the only realized Ontology

Deleuze's method is thus a method that rejects all recourse to mediations; indeed, this is the being). But Deleuze immediately raises the objection that "There are not two 'paths', as Parmenides

> The three planes, along with their elements, are irreducible_: plane of immanence of philosophy

Paul Klee. *Heads*, 1913

Notes

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